



Aerial evidence

This photograph taken by a USAF reconnaissance plane shows a patrol boat belonging to the Khmer Rouge alongside the SS *Mayaguez*, soon after the attack on the container ship.

Ford orders the attack

The Khmer Rouge took the ship to Koh Tang, an island about 32 miles (52 km) from the Cambodian coast, where they transferred the 39 crew members to fishing vessels. These boats took the *Mayaguez* crew to another small island nearby and then attempted to move them to the mainland at Kompong Som (the former Sihanoukville). Realizing that the crew would be harder to track once they reached the mainland, Ford determined to rescue them first. However, American pilots lost track of the boat among the hundreds of fishing vessels in Kompong Som's harbor, and the Pentagon's lack of information about the area complicated its rescue plans.

President Ford authorized a naval, air, and landing operation to retake the *Mayaguez*, assault Koh Tang island, and bomb Kompong Som. While the first and last objectives were achieved easily—the ship itself had already been abandoned—the attack on Koh Tang was more challenging. The Marine and Air Force landing party found the island far better defended than their intelligence briefings had indicated.